

PROJECT CLOSE-OUT REPORT

West Africa Undergraduate & Early Developer Hackathon (*Cultivating the Next Generation of Cardano Innovators*)

Project ID: #1300192

Fund: Cardano Project Catalyst — Fund 13

Category: Cardano Open: Ecosystem

Project Lead: Duke Peter

Implementing Organization: Better Africa Foundation

Technical Partner: Remostart

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Close-Out Video:  [NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 | Closeout Video](#)

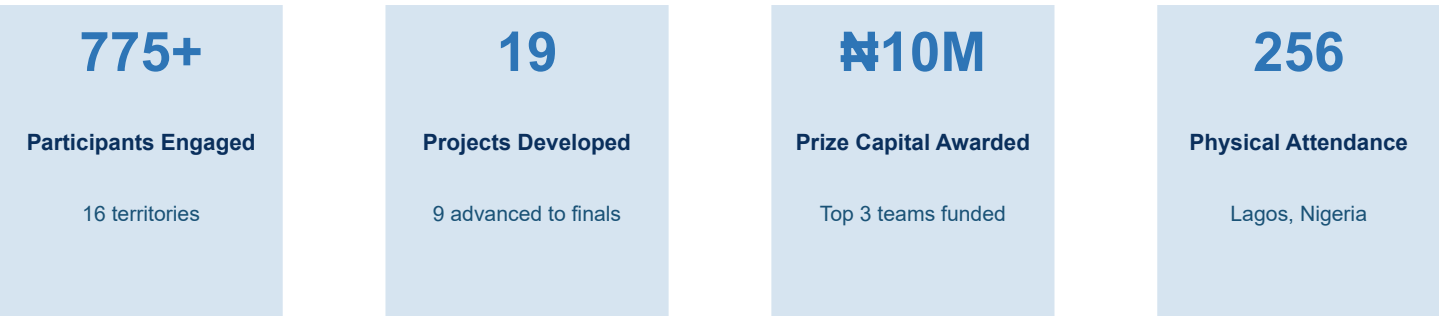
1. Executive Summary

The NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025, formally designated the West Africa Undergraduate & Early Developer Hackathon and funded under Cardano Project Catalyst Fund 13 (ID: #1300192), was not conceived as a mere competition. It was conceived to tackle an infrastructural problem.

Across sub-Saharan Africa, the gap between technical education and meaningful employment in emerging technology sectors is structural. Hundreds of thousands of graduates enter the workforce annually, yet the pathways connecting early-stage talent to global blockchain and decentralized technology ecosystems remain underdeveloped, largely inaccessible, and inadequately resourced. The result is a consistent outflow of capable individuals who either disengage from technology altogether or seek opportunities outside the continent.

The West Africa Undergraduate & Early Developer Hackathon was designed as a direct countermeasure: a structured, six-month pipeline that moved participants from first exposure to demonstrated capability, and from the periphery of a global ecosystem to its active edge.

Over the project cycle spanning February to June 2025, the initiative engaged 775+ participants across 16 territories — 15 Nigerian states and Ghana. Six foundational workshops introduced participants to Cardano's technical architecture. 19 teams developed original blockchain solutions addressing documented real-world problems. 9 finalist teams presented live to an expert evaluation panel in Lagos. 3 teams received early-stage grant capital totalling ₦10,000,000 — the largest single hackathon prize pool for a Cardano-focused project at the University of Lagos to date.



The project delivered on all four Catalyst milestones. It did so in an environment defined by systemic infrastructure constraints, logistical complexity across 16 geographies, flight disruptions affecting key personnel, and — most consequentially — an internal governance breach that caused significant data loss and required emergency account recovery. That the project exceeded the majority of its committed targets under these conditions is not incidental. It reflects deliberate design choices: redundant infrastructure, adaptive operational protocols, and a team structure capable of making fast, sound decisions under pressure.

This report constitutes the final close-out submission for Milestone 4. It documents outcomes and impact with full verifiability, provides a transparent account of challenges and institutional responses, and articulates the strategic foundation from which the next iteration of this project will be built.

2. Strategic Context: Why This Problem Matters

2.1 The Structural Gap in African Technology Ecosystems

Africa's technology workforce challenge is not a talent deficit, but a pipeline deficit.

Nigeria alone produces hundreds of thousands of graduates annually across science, technology, engineering, and mathematics disciplines. Yet the majority of these graduates lack structured access to the tools, mentorship, community, and early-stage capital required to transition from academic learning into meaningful participation in global technology ecosystems, particularly those built on decentralized infrastructure.

Blockchain ecosystems are particularly acute in this regard. Unlike conventional software development, where tutorials, bootcamps, and open-source communities provide reasonably accessible onboarding paths, decentralized technology platforms require exposure to novel mental models — smart contract logic, cryptographic ownership, tokenomics, on-chain governance — that are rarely covered in standard university curricula. For early-stage builders encountering these concepts for the first time, the absence of structured onboarding is not merely inconvenient. It is a functional barrier to entry.

The downstream consequence is predictable: talented early-career technologists remain disengaged from ecosystems that would benefit enormously from their contributions, while those ecosystems — Cardano among them — face a persistent shortage of builder capacity in regions of the world experiencing the fastest demographic growth.

2.2 The Cardano Context

Cardano is a third-generation blockchain protocol built on a peer-reviewed research foundation, with a growing smart contract ecosystem and an evolving community governance model through Project Catalyst. Catalyst is one of the largest decentralized funding mechanisms in the blockchain space, enabling ADA holders to allocate development resources through a community-driven voting process.

However, meaningful participation in this system requires more than awareness; it demands both technical competence and community fluency to successfully propose, build, and deliver projects.

For West Africa to emerge as a substantive contributor to the Cardano ecosystem rather than a passive beneficiary, developers in the region need structured entry points. The NextGen Developers Hackathon was designed to provide exactly that.

3. Theory of Change & Project Design

3.1 Design Rationale

The project was anchored on a deliberate theory of change: if early-stage builders are given structured access to knowledge, tooling, mentorship, and early capital, in a format designed for their specific context, they can transition from passive learners to active contributors within global innovation ecosystems.

The key phrase is 'designed for their specific context.' Generic hackathons that assume stable internet connectivity, prior blockchain familiarity, and access to development infrastructure consistently underperform in African settings. The NextGen Hackathon was built differently: with offline-first contingency planning, geography-inclusive participation structures, a pre-hackathon education layer before any competitive element began, and a prize structure that rewarded early-stage promise rather than deployment readiness.

3.2 The Six-Stage Pipeline

The project operationalized its theory of change through a deliberate six-stage progression:

- **Access** — Lowering barriers to entry through open, geography-inclusive participation with no prerequisites.
- **Learning** — Delivering foundational technical education through six structured interactive workshops.
- **Building** — Enabling hands-on application through team-based project development with continuous mentor support.
- **Validation** — Providing a structured demo and evaluation platform against rigorous, expert-assessed criteria.
- **Funding** — Awarding early-stage capital to the most promising solutions, creating immediate ecosystem investment.
- **Continuity** — Sustaining engagement through post-project mentorship, student club formation, and pathway support into future Catalyst funding rounds.

The significance of this model is that it is not designed to produce a single cohort outcome. It is designed to produce ongoing pipeline capacity with participants who are now ecosystem-aware, technically oriented, and positioned to continue building, contributing, and proposing within Cardano and adjacent decentralized platforms.

3.3 Milestone Structure & Delivery

#	Milestone	Status
M1	Preparatory Phase & Partnerships	Completed ✓
M2	Pre-Hackathon Workshops & Training	Completed ✓
M3	Hackathon Event	Completed ✓
M4	Final Close-Out Report & Video	Completed ✓

4. Programme Implementation

4.1 Phase One: Learning

The project launched with six structured virtual workshops delivered over several weeks. Each session covered a distinct layer of the Cardano technical stack: blockchain fundamentals, Cardano ecosystem architecture, smart contract concepts, product development methodology, Catalyst proposal frameworks, and developer tooling. The sequencing was deliberate: each session built on the previous, moving participants from conceptual orientation to practical readiness without assuming prior knowledge.

Sessions were designed as interactive engagements rather than passive instruction. Live Q&A, conceptual exercises, and team ideation prompts were embedded throughout. Participants had access to dedicated mentors during sessions while one-on-one support was made available on request after the sessions.

Training resources & decks:  [GitHub - betterafricafdn/NextGen-Africa: Cardano Hackathon](#)

4.2 Phase Two: Building

Following the training phase, participants transitioned into team formation and project development. Teams used GitHub for version control and collaboration, and design platforms for UI/UX prototyping. Mentors provided ongoing technical guidance throughout this phase, with structured check-in points designed to maintain momentum and surface blockers early.

A critical design decision was made at the outset: full technical deployment was explicitly not the primary evaluative criterion for most teams. The participant profile was predominantly beginner — many encountering blockchain development concepts for the first time. Requiring deployment-ready products would have either excluded the majority of participants or incentivized superficial execution over genuine learning. Instead, the project focused on enabling the transition from conceptual understanding to demonstrable, documented output, a design choice that proved correct. 19 teams submitted projects, representing a broader range of real-world problem domains than anticipated.

All submitted projects:  [Github Repo Links of The Participants Projects](#)

4.3 Phase Three: Demo & Pitch

The final phase was executed in a hybrid format: Day 1 hosted a virtual session focused on educating Cardano's Project Catalyst and How African Innovators can unlock pathways to funding for their ideas after the Hackathon. Day 2 was the physical event which held in Lagos, Nigeria.

Lagos was selected as the host city because it is, unambiguously, Africa's most dynamic technology and commercial ecosystem. As Nigeria's economic capital and the continent's largest city by population, Lagos concentrates the highest density of technology investors, startup founders, blockchain practitioners, corporate sponsors, and specialist media in the region giving the project access to a calibre of judges, partners, and public visibility that no other Nigerian city could match. Its infrastructure of co-working spaces, event venues, and a well-established tech community also provided the operational scaffolding necessary for a credible, professionally executed physical event. For participants travelling from across Nigeria, Lagos carried inherent prestige. Executing this in Lagos testified that the project was operating at the level of Nigeria's most serious technology conversations, not at its margins.

The University of Lagos was then the natural choice within the city. As Nigeria's most prominent research and technology-oriented university, UNILAG sits at the intersection of academic credibility and active industry engagement, with faculties in engineering, computing, and applied sciences producing precisely the undergraduate and early-career developer profile the project was designed to serve. Its large, organized student population provided both a ready participant base and an established club infrastructure through which post-hackathon community continuity could be anchored. Hosting the event at UNILAG also carried deliberate institutional signal: for participants arriving from across the country, presenting their work at Nigeria's foremost university raised the perceived stakes of competition and communicated a level of seriousness that directly shaped the quality of engagement the project received.

9 finalist teams presented their solutions to an evaluation panel. Scoring criteria encompassed technical implementation, problem relevance, innovation quality, and potential for continued development within the Cardano ecosystem while 3 teams were awarded prizes totalling ₦10,000,000.

Event photos and video highlights:  [next gen videos - Google Drive](#)

 [Next Gen Photos - Google Drive](#)

5. Outcomes & Impact

5.1 KPI Performance

Key Performance Indicator	Target	Actual	%	Status
Participants Engaged	500+	775+	155%	EXCEEDED
States / Countries Reached	5	16	220%	EXCEEDED
Physical Event Attendance	200+	256	128%	EXCEEDED
Teams Formed & Projects Built	15+	19	127%	EXCEEDED
Teams Advanced to Finals	9	9	100%	MET
Awards Distributed	3	3	100%	MET
Female Participation	30%	28%	93%	NEAR MET
Pre-Hackathon Workshops	6	6	100%	MET
Grant Funding Awarded (NGN)	₦10M	₦10M	100%	DELIVERED
New Cardano Wallets Created	100+	100+	100%	MET
Partnerships	5	13	160%	EXCEEDED

The project met and exceeded the majority of its committed targets. The most significant overperformance was in regional reach, reflecting organic interest that extended well beyond initial projections and validated the model's resonance with the target audience. Locations reached exceeded target by 120%, partnerships by 60%, participant engagement by 55%, physical attendance by 28%, and teams developed by 27%.

Female participation reached 28% against a 30% target. While this fell a little short, it represents meaningful progress in an ecosystem where women consistently remain underrepresented. The project's next iteration has

set a revised target of 40%, and we will target partnerships with women-in-tech organizations for more inclusivity.

5.2 Capability Creation: What the Numbers Actually Represent

The most consequential impact of this project cannot be fully captured in KPI tables. It lies in the individual-level shift it catalyzed across a cohort that was, almost entirely, encountering decentralized application development for the first time and in what that shift means, concretely, for the long-term health and growth of the Cardano ecosystem in Africa.

Consider what 775 registrations represents in ecosystem terms. These were not passive sign-ups but potential builders and developers. Over 60 of them engaged the structured six-week technical curriculum, formed or joined development teams, and built original solutions on or for the Cardano blockchain. 256 attended the physical event in Lagos; 19 teams submitted complete projects; 9 finalist teams presented their work live before an expert evaluation panel; and 3 teams received early-stage grant capital and are in active post-hackathon development. Every one of these participants now has direct, functional familiarity with Cardano's architecture, tooling, and ecosystem. Knowledge they did not possess before this project began.

More tangibly: over 100 new Cardano wallets were created during the project. Each wallet represents a person who has crossed the threshold from curiosity, to awareness to participation. In ecosystem growth terms, that is the most valuable conversion a developer onboarding project can produce.

The sustainability of this growth is anchored in the 5 Cardano student clubs established across participating universities as a direct project output. With bi-weekly mentorship sessions, documented membership, and active faculty engagement, these clubs will produce builders and developers continuously. Each semester will bring new cohort of undergraduates into structured contact with Cardano's ecosystem, mentored by peers who went through the hackathon and stayed. This is compounding growth: the project ends, but the pipeline it built does not.

Post-hackathon engagement has been deliberately maintained. Winning teams and top-performing participants have been briefed on the Catalyst proposal process and are being supported toward submitting their own proposals in future rounds thereby transitioning from hackathon participants to independent ecosystem contributors. Several participants have also expressed interest in engaging with Cardano's Intersect governance structure as it develops, representing a further dimension of ecosystem integration that extends well beyond the project's formal close.

What this project delivered to the Cardano community, in sum, is not a headcount. It is a verified, structured entry of over 775 individuals into ecosystem awareness, 100+ into active on-chain participation, 19 teams into the builder tier, 5 institutional nodes through which that growth will continue to compound long after this report is filed and 3 winners whose products represent the future of Africa built on the Cardano blockchain.



5.3 Inclusion & Accessibility

Inclusion was a deliberate design principle, not a reporting metric. Targeted outreach contributed to 28% female participation. The project extended remote participation options and, where feasible, financially supported internet access to ensure geographical and financial constraints did not function as barriers to entry. The extension of reach to Ghana and across 15 Nigerian states reflects the accessibility infrastructure built into the project's design from the outset.

5.4 Media Coverage & Independent Validation

The project's reach extended beyond participant numbers. The NextGen Developers Hackathon attracted independent coverage from technology news platforms, startup communities, and scholarship networks across Africa, reflecting the project's credibility and the genuine public interest it generated. Key publications include:

Post-Event

- Punch Newspaper — [🌐 Hackathon channels capital into student tech startups](#)
- Vantage Network Africa — [🌐 NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 for Young Africans](#)
- MSME — [🌐 NextGen Hackathon Empowers 775 Young Developers in Nigeria and Ghana with -](#)
- Corporate Responsibility and Sustainability Watch — [🌐 775 Developers Trained and Funded as NextGen Hackathon Boosts Tech Talent in Nigeria and Gha...](#)

Pre-Event

- Opportunity Desk — [🌐 NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 for Young Africans \(up to N10,000,000 in prizes\)](#)
- Startup Lagos — [in Apply for NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 | Startup Lagos posted on the topic | LinkedIn](#)
- Techbuild Africa — [🌐 Young African Innovator? Apply for NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 \(₦10M\)](#)
- ScholarshipBob — [🌐 NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 for Young Africans \(up to N10,000,000 in prizes\) | Scholarship...](#)
- NGGossips — [in NextGen Developers Hackathon Boosts Africa's Tech Economy | NGGOSSIPs posted on the t...](#)
- Oya Opportunities — [🌐 NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 for Young Africans \(up to N10,000,000 in prizes\) - OYA Opport...](#)

Collectively, these publications confirm that the NextGen Developers Hackathon was not a closed, internal event. It was a publicly documented intervention in West Africa's technology development landscape, recognized by independent media and startup communities

6. Notable Solutions: What the Builders Built

The 9 finalist projects spanned digital security, environmental monitoring, real estate, education, e-commerce, and decentralized finance. Their breadth reflects both the quality of the education phase and the genuine problem-awareness of the participant cohort.

Place	Team	Sector	Solution Overview
1st	K33P	Digital Security	Decentralised vault for secure private key storage and recovery — addressing one of the most acute pain points in digital asset ownership for non-expert users.
2nd	EcoReport	Climate & Environment	Community-driven environmental reporting anchored to the Cardano blockchain, creating a tamper-resistant audit trail for sustainability data across Africa.
3rd	SafeNest	Real Estate	Smart contract-powered property verification layer enabling buyers to authenticate ownership records before transacting — directly countering Nigeria's pervasive real estate fraud problem.
Finalist	Rentify	Rental & Lifestyle	All-in-one rental marketplace: flights, hotels, car and venue rental, asset listing.
Finalist	Solution Web	Education	Decentralized e-learning platform built for students, by students.
Finalist	Alpha Team	Real Estate	Decentralized platform for land title security.
Finalist	Nextraden	E-Commerce	Decentralized peer-to-peer commerce platform.
Finalist	Unspecified Bit	NFT / Digital Assets	NFT trading and marketplace platform on the Cardano blockchain.
Finalist	Ratify	Crowdfunding	Decentralized crowdfunding infrastructure on Cardano.

6.1 Award-Winning Projects in Detail

K33P — 1st Place | Digital Security

K33P addresses one of the most acute pain points in digital asset ownership: the loss of private keys, which permanently and irrevocably severs users from their wallets and assets. The solution developed a decentralized vault architecture for secure private key storage and recovery, combining cryptographic protection with accessible user flows designed for non-expert users. The approach is technically sound and addresses a problem of genuine scale within the Cardano ecosystem and the broader crypto space — one that currently has no dominant consumer-grade solution.

EcoReport — 2nd Place | Climate & Environment

EcoReport leverages blockchain's core property — immutability — to address a persistent challenge in environmental monitoring: the integrity and traceability of community-generated data. By anchoring environmental reports to the Cardano blockchain, the solution creates a verifiable audit trail resistant to manipulation or selective disclosure. The use case aligns with growing institutional demand for verified sustainability data across Africa, where environmental reporting is both critically important and chronically unreliable.

SafeNest — 3rd Place | Real Estate

Real estate fraud is among the most economically damaging forms of property crime in Nigeria, with fraudulent title documents causing substantial financial losses annually. SafeNest deploys smart contract logic to create a transparent property verification layer, enabling buyers to authenticate ownership records before transacting. The product concept addresses a high-frequency, high-stakes problem with clear market applicability — and represents exactly the kind of locally-grounded, globally-relevant solution the NextGen project was designed to cultivate.

7. Contribution to the Cardano Ecosystem

7.1 Large-Scale Onboarding

The project's most direct contribution to the Cardano ecosystem is scale-level onboarding. Hundreds of participants gained working familiarity with Cardano's documentation, developer tooling, wallet infrastructure, and community governance model for the first time. Over 100 new Cardano wallets were created during the project representing direct activation, not theoretical awareness.

GitHub engagement across all nineteen participating teams demonstrates active development practice rather than passive exposure. What this shows is that these participants are not in the ecosystem's peripheral audience but in its builder tier. They may be at an early stage, but still within it.

7.2 Developer Pipeline Creation

Perhaps more significant than the current cohort is what it represents as a forward pipeline. Several funded teams are now in active post-hackathon development, with progress being monitored and mentorship support maintained. Multiple participants have expressed interest in future Catalyst funding rounds. Others are positioned to engage with Cardano's Intersect governance structure as it matures.

The project's student club framework — with five Cardano student clubs established across participating universities, supported by bi-weekly mentorship sessions and documented membership — provides the

ongoing infrastructure through which this pipeline will continue to flow. Student clubs do not produce developers in a single cycle. They produce them continuously.

7.3 Proof of Model for Emerging Markets

Beyond West Africa, the project contributes a validated operational model for ecosystem onboarding in environments characterized by infrastructure constraints, geographic distribution, and early-stage builder profiles. The combination of offline-first delivery design, pre-competition education layers, and community-anchored follow-through addresses the specific failure modes that cause similar projects elsewhere to underperform in these contexts.

This has implications beyond Cardano. As decentralized ecosystems seek to expand into high-growth emerging markets — a strategic priority shared across most major blockchain platforms — they face a consistent challenge: the absence of locally adapted onboarding infrastructure. The NextGen model demonstrates what that infrastructure can look like in practice.

8. Leadership & Execution Under Constraint

The delivery of a multi-state project of this scope, organized remotely, executed across one of Africa's most operationally complex environments, and dependent on coordination across multiple stakeholder groups, presented material challenges at every phase. This section spotlights a structured, transparent account of each significant obstacle and the decision-making it required.

Remote Project Delivery Across a Distributed Team

C1

Lagos was selected as the physical event city based on its unmatched position as Africa's premier hub for technology, investment, and commerce — maximizing access to high-calibre judges, sponsors, and media partners. However, with all core team members located outside Lagos at the time of delivery, full logistical execution — venue management, catering, equipment setup, on-ground coordination, and participant management — required building and remotely managing a dedicated local team who had not been part of the project's planning phase.

Response: The team created a volunteer network of student's in University of Lagos and developed structured coordination protocols including daily/weekly briefing cycles, real-time communication channels, and clear escalation paths. Volunteers were provided with detailed operational runbooks covering every event segment. Remote oversight was maintained continuously by core team leads throughout execution.

C2

Nationwide Internet Instability

Nigeria experienced severe and widespread internet degradation throughout the project's period, affecting both virtual training sessions and the main event. In anticipation of connectivity risks, the team invested in routers across the three largest internet service providers in the country and established mobile hotspot backups from multiple carriers. Despite this multi-layered contingency infrastructure, the Day 1 virtual session was significantly disrupted — approximately 86 participants were unable to complete the planned agenda — and live streaming during the physical event could not be maintained.

Response: The team pivoted to offline-first delivery wherever possible, recording all sessions for subsequent distribution and maintaining direct communication with virtual participants through alternative channels. All recorded content was made available to participants who could not engage live. The disruption was significant but contained and no milestone deliverables were compromised.

C3

Flight Disruptions Affecting Judges, Speakers & Mentors

On the day of the physical event, multiple confirmed judges, speakers, and mentors were stranded at airports across Nigeria due to widespread domestic flight delays and undue cancellations. Only one original panel judge reached Lagos on the day — via indirect routing — arriving as the event was concluding.

Response: A contingency judging panel was immediately activated from qualified professionals within the network of Duke Peter, the project lead — individuals with technology and business expertise. While some panel members had limited direct exposure to the Cardano ecosystem specifically, their professional calibre ensured evaluations remained rigorous and grounded in product quality and real-world applicability. Scoring rubrics were briefed in advance to ensure consistency across the panel.

C4

Internal Governance Breach & Data Loss

The most consequential disruption to the project arose from an internal conduct issue. A supporting team member was formally dismissed after it was determined that his conduct constituted a direct conflict of interest: his elder brother was a competing participant, and the dismissed team member made active attempts to manipulate the evaluation process in his sibling's favour.

This conduct was in direct violation of the project's integrity framework and the principles of inclusivity that sit at its core. The dismissal was immediate and non-negotiable.

Following the dismissal, the former team member intentionally altered the login credentials, two-factor authentication recovery settings, and all associated contact information for the organization's primary Google account, effectively locking the organization out of the account and all connected social media platforms. As a result, the organization was unable to access its core digital infrastructure for approximately six months. Access was eventually restored through a previously authenticated device that retained passkey authorization. Upon regaining control, the organization discovered that several files had been deleted. Despite multiple recovery attempts, some of the deleted files have not been successfully restored.

Response: The organization immediately implemented revised access control protocols, separating administrative and operational permissions, and formalized procedures for credential management and offboarding. All sensitive organizational accounts have been secured under multi-administrator control structures. A formal criminal complaint will be pursued under Nigerian cybercrimes legislation to prosecute the perpetrator.

9. Lessons Learned & Risk Architecture

Each operational challenge generated actionable institutional learning. The following framework maps each challenge to its corresponding lesson and the specific mitigation that will be embedded in future project delivery.

Challenge	Lesson Learned	Future Mitigation
Remote Project Delivery	Remote coordination is viable but demands investment in governance infrastructure, escalation protocols, and runbooks — established well before execution, not during it.	Formal On-Ground Operations Manual for future events. Minimum 72-hour pre-event briefing with all on-ground staff. Dedicated remote liaison assigned per coordinator.
Internet Instability	Redundant connectivity (multiple ISPs + hotspots) is necessary but insufficient where infrastructure degradation is systemic. Contingency planning must match the scale of environmental risk.	Venue-level connectivity SLA requirements at selection stage. Satellite internet (Starlink or equivalent) as tertiary backup. All content designed for offline-first delivery as default.
Flight Disruptions	Same-day travel creates unacceptable single points of failure for critical personnel. The contingency judging panel validated the importance of pre-identifying and briefing backup roles in advance.	Judges, speakers, and mentors with external travel requirements arrive a minimum of 24 hours before the event. Pre-briefed reserve judge panel maintained as standard practice.
Governance Breach & Data Loss	Administrative access to organizational systems must be tightly scoped, with separation between operational access and account ownership. Offboarding must begin with immediate revocation — before any communication with the departing individual.	Formal Access Control Policy with tiered permissions. Critical files maintained in two independent cloud repositories under separate administrative accounts. Offboarding checklists triggered at the point of decision, not disclosure.

Three cross-cutting institutional measures will be formalized before the next project iteration launches:

- Legal framework — All team member agreements will include confidentiality, data handling, and conflict of interest clauses executed prior to project commencement.
- Evidence protocols — A real-time evidence collection workflow (photography, attendance logs, testimonials) will operate from Day 1 of each project phase, eliminating any dependence on post-event reconstruction of deliverables.

10. A Replicable Model for Ecosystem Onboarding

The NextGen Developers Hackathon was designed from the outset as a replicable framework not as a standalone event. Its core architecture is transferable, and its operational learnings actively improve it for deployment in comparable contexts.

The model's core components are: pre-competition technical education delivered at the participants' level; geography-inclusive participation infrastructure that does not assume connectivity; structured team development with continuous mentor access; a hybrid demo format that accommodates distributed audiences; post-project capital deployment to the most promising teams; and community infrastructure (student clubs, mentorship channels) that sustains engagement between project cycles.

Each of these components addresses a specific failure mode observed in projects that underperform in West African settings. The combination produces outcomes that generic hackathon models — designed for contexts with stable infrastructure and pre-existing technical communities — consistently fail to achieve.

The model is expandable across West Africa and applicable in comparable emerging market contexts globally: East Africa, Southeast Asia, South Asia, and Latin America all present the same structural combination of growing graduate populations, infrastructure constraints, and underdeveloped blockchain ecosystem onboarding pathways. The operational playbook developed through this project is directly relevant to each of those contexts.

11. Sustainability & Forward Trajectory

11.1 Post-Hackathon Team Activity

The three award-winning teams — K33P, EcoReport, and SafeNest — have received their grant funding and are in the active continuation phase of product development. Contact has been maintained with all three teams and development progress is being monitored against post-hackathon expectations. Repository links and development updates are publicly accessible via the project's GitHub.

11.2 Student Club Infrastructure

The project's milestone framework committed to the establishment of five Cardano student clubs across participating universities, with bi-weekly mentorship sessions and documented membership. All five clubs have been established. Constitutions, membership lists, and mentorship session recordings are available via the project's documentation repository. These clubs represent the project's most durable institutional output making it an ongoing infrastructure through which new builders continue to enter the ecosystem beyond any individual project cycle.

11.3 NextGen Hackathon 2.0: Planned Improvements

The second iteration of the NextGen Developers Hackathon is in planning, incorporating the full set of operational and governance learnings from this cycle. Key areas of improvement include:

- Expanded regional footprint — dedicated on-ground presence in Ghana and at least one additional West African country.
- Post-hackathon acceleration structure — structured Catalyst proposal preparation support for top-performing teams, creating a direct pipeline from hackathon winner to funded Catalyst project.

- Female participation target of 40% — supported by targeted partnerships with women-in-tech organizations across the region.
- Starlink or equivalent satellite internet as primary connectivity infrastructure for all physical events.
- Formalized legal and governance framework for all team members and partners, executed before project launch.

The next iteration will not simply repeat the model at larger scale. It will advance it by incorporating the lessons of this cycle, deepening the post-project acceleration structure, and building towards a continental project capable of producing Catalyst-ready teams as a consistent output rather than a hoped-for outcome.

12. Project Team and Organizational Structure

The NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 was delivered by a lean, cross-functional team whose combined strengths in ecosystem strategy, operations, community engagement, blockchain development, creative execution, and communications enabled the project to meet and exceed its intended outcomes under materially challenging conditions. What the team lacked in size, it compensated for in clarity of roles, commitment to the project's mission, and the capacity to make sound operational decisions quickly, a quality that proved decisive during the periods of disruption documented in this report.

• **Duke Peter — Project Lead**

Duke Peter is an ecosystem architect and innovation strategist working at the intersection of AI, blockchain, and community-driven development across Africa, with over three years of experience building and managing high-impact technology communities.

As Project Lead of the NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025, Duke did not simply execute a project, he engineered a structured talent pipeline, designing the initiative from the ground up as a scalable onboarding infrastructure for early-stage builders across the Cardano ecosystem. His leadership combined strategic foresight with operational resilience: securing the Fund 13 grant, architecting the project's theory of change and milestone framework, navigating a governance breach that threatened core organizational infrastructure, and ensuring that every milestone commitment was met without compromising the quality of participant experience or ecosystem outcomes.

To date, his ability to translate vision into structured, fundable, and deliverable project's has enabled him to secure over \$50,000 in direct grant funding across multiple initiatives positioning him not merely as a participant in Africa's technology ecosystem, but as one of its active builders.

His broader work spans ecosystem development with the Better Africa Foundation, AI ethics/governance engagement through SingularityNET Africa and BGI Nexus and community governance participation within Cardano's Project Catalyst and Intersect all of which are anchored in a consistent thesis: that Africa's technological future must be built through indigenous capacity, community ownership, and innovation infrastructure designed for long-term ecosystem growth, not isolated interventions.

• **PraiseGod Bassey — Chief Operating Officer, Better Africa Foundation**

PraiseGod is an operations leader with a multidisciplinary background spanning public health, gender equity, and technology-enabled social impact. A combination that brings both systems thinking and a

participant-centred lens to large-scale project delivery. As Chief Operating Officer of the Better Africa Foundation and the NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025, she held responsibility for operational execution across the full project lifecycle: logistics coordination, participant management, stakeholder communication, and the internal workflow systems that kept a distributed, multi-state initiative functioning cohesively and on schedule.

Her role was particularly critical in managing participant experience at scale — supporting over 256 participants across 16 territories through both virtual and physical project components, with an emphasis on accessibility, clarity, and responsiveness at every touchpoint. During periods of disruption, including nationwide internet instability and the complexities of coordinating a physical event entirely remotely, PraiseGod maintained operational continuity through structured communication channels, real-time decision-making, and direct support to on-ground teams ensuring that no phase of delivery lost momentum.

Beyond the NextGen Hackathon, she is building FEM365, a digital health initiative focused on expanding access to inclusive healthcare services for women and girls in underserved communities. Work that reflects the same commitment to operational excellence and inclusive delivery that defined her contribution to this project.

- **Lazarus Christian Chinaza — Project Manager**

Lazarus is a project management professional with a background in mechanical engineering, a graduate membership of the Nigerian Society of Engineers, and published research in sustainable systems engineering, a combination that brings both analytical rigour and structured thinking to complex, multi-stakeholder project delivery.

As Project Manager for the NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025, he served as the central coordination layer across all four project phases translating strategic direction into executable tasks, maintaining alignment across a distributed volunteer team, and ensuring that milestone commitments were tracked and met without exception. His responsibilities extended across workstream coordination, participant engagement, project communications, and on-ground event logistics, making him the operational thread that ran through every stage of delivery. Post-hackathon, Lazarus continued to coordinate the support programme for the teams, monitoring development progress and supporting alignment through to grant disbursement.

During the project's most challenging periods, including the internal governance disruption, he maintained delivery focus and ensured that no timeline or output was compromised. Beyond his execution role, Lazarus participates actively in Cardano governance through Intersect MBO — reflecting a broader ecosystem investment that strengthens the bridge between the early-stage talent this programme develops and the sustained participation the ecosystem needs.

- **Ese Williams — Marketing Lead, Remostart**

Ese Williams led the project's outreach and participant acquisition strategy, designing and executing the campaigns that drove 775+ registrations across Nigeria and Ghana — above the project's original target. Working from Remostart's marketing infrastructure, she built a multi-channel outreach architecture that reached university communities, tech hubs, scholarship networks, social media ecosystems, and national media simultaneously.

The geographic diversity of the project's participant base reflects the deliberate breadth of her campaign design. She also managed media partner relationships, including the Punch Newspaper coverage and the Opportunity Desk distribution partnership, both of which extended the programme's reach into audiences well beyond the immediate blockchain and startup communities.

- **David Femi — Visual Strategist**

David Femi is a visual strategist specializing in brand systems, narrative design, and digital communication for technology-driven initiatives. His work focuses on translating complex ideas into compelling visual experiences that not only attract attention but shape perception and reinforce project credibility.

For the NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025, David led the development of the project's visual identity and strategic design direction across all touchpoints. From promotional campaigns to workshop materials and event collateral, he ensured that every visual output aligned with the project's positioning as a high-quality, globally relevant initiative.

Beyond aesthetics, David's approach integrated design with communication strategy, enabling the project to stand out in a competitive ecosystem despite limited marketing resources. His work strengthened audience engagement, enhanced brand consistency, and contributed to the overall perception of NextGen as a structured and professional platform for emerging builders.

- **Volunteers — Project Facilitators & Community Coordinators**

15 volunteers contributed substantively to the project's delivery across both virtual and physical components. Their responsibilities spanned workshop facilitation support, participant onboarding assistance, technical/non-technical helpdesk functions, physical event coordination, social media monitoring, and real-time communication management during the Lagos event. For a project operating at this scale with a core team of five, the volunteer layer was structurally necessary not supplementary. Several volunteers were drawn from the University of Lagos student community, introducing more new people Cardano and giving them ecosystem familiarity that enhanced the quality of support they provided to other participants also encountering the ecosystem for the first time. Their contribution extended the project's reach and responsiveness in ways that the core team alone could not have sustained.

The collective capacity of this team i.e its range of skills, its operational discipline, and its ability to maintain performance under the conditions documented in this report, reflects the kind of organizational culture that produces credible, replicable projects rather than one-off events. Future iterations of the NextGen Hackathon will be built on this foundation, with expanded team capacity matched to the expanded scope of what the project is now positioned to deliver.

13. Partnerships & Institutional Collaborators

The NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025 was not delivered by a single organization. It was delivered through a deliberately assembled network of institutional partners whose combined reach, credibility, and technical capacity extended the project's impact well beyond what any single entity could have achieved. Each partnership was selected to fill a specific function in the project's delivery architecture from infrastructure and academic credibility, to community mobilization, media amplification, and opportunity dissemination.

a) Academic & Institutional Partners

The **University of Lagos Computer Science Department** served as the project's primary academic anchor, providing institutional credibility, direct access to the undergraduate developer community the project was designed to serve, and the physical infrastructure that made the Lagos event possible. The department's endorsement positioned the hackathon within Nigeria's most recognized technology faculty, lending the project a level of academic legitimacy that significantly shaped participant perception and engagement quality.

Wellspring University, Benin, Ahmadu Bello University (ABU), Zaria, Blockchain LASU Community, University of Lagos Science Education Student's Association (ULSESA), Nigeria Association of Computing Students (NACOS) extended the project's university reach beyond Lagos, enabling participation from Nigeria's South-South and Northern regions respectively. Their involvement was critical to the project's claim of national representation ensuring that the hackathon was not a Lagos-centric initiative but a genuinely pan-Nigerian one, accessible to talented early-stage developers regardless of geography.

b) Ecosystem & Community Partners

The **Unified Cardano Student's Club** was the project's most strategically significant community partner. As the coordinating body for Cardano-focused student communities across Nigerian universities, the club provided immediate access to a pre-organized, ecosystem-aware participant base, facilitated the establishment of new student clubs at participating institutions, and created the structural continuity infrastructure through which post-hackathon engagement has been sustained. The partnership between the NextGen Hackathon and the Unified Cardano Students' Club is, in effect, the mechanism through which this project's impact compounds beyond its formal close.

The **SingularityNET AI Student Club** brought an AI-native community perspective into the project's participant network, enriching the cross-disciplinary dimension of solutions developed during the hackathon and deepening the range of technical approaches teams applied to real-world problems.

c) Technical & Delivery Partners

Remostart served as the project's principal technical partner, providing delivery infrastructure, mentorship, talent, and operational capacity across multiple workstreams. Their newly built lab, **Remostart AI and Blockchain Labs** specifically contributed technical mentorship, blockchain development expertise, hands-on workshop facilitation and their facility, providing participants with post-hackathon practitioner-level guidance that classroom instruction alone cannot replicate. The depth of Remostart's involvement across both project delivery and technical education was a significant factor in the quality of solutions produced by participating teams.

Better Africa Foundation, as the implementing organization, provided the institutional framework, grant management infrastructure, and organizational leadership through which all project activities were executed and all Catalyst milestone commitments were met.

d) Media & Communications Partners

Punch Newspaper — one of Nigeria's most widely read and editorially respected national publications — provided press coverage that amplified the project's reach into mainstream public discourse, beyond the technology and startup communities in which hackathon projects typically circulate. Coverage in Punch

communicated the project's significance to a broad national audience and strengthened its credibility as a serious, newsworthy intervention in Nigeria's technology development landscape.

Brandmedic Media managed the project's creative communications strategy across digital channels, ensuring consistent brand presence, professional visual execution, and sustained audience engagement throughout the project cycle. Their work directly contributed to the quality of public perception the project generated and the organic media interest it attracted.

e) Opportunity Distribution Partners

Opportunity Desk — a globally recognized platform connecting young people across Africa and beyond to scholarships, fellowships, competitions, and development opportunities — distributed the project's call for applications to its extensive subscriber base. This single partnership was instrumental in extending project awareness beyond Nigeria's immediate technology community and contributed directly to the geographic diversity of applications received, including from Ghana and multiple states across Nigeria.

Collectively, these partnerships represent a cross-sector coalition spanning academia, blockchain ecosystem communities, artificial intelligence, technical infrastructure, national media, and global opportunity networks. The project's impact was, in significant part, a function of the quality and alignment of this partner network. Future iterations of the project will deepen these relationships and expand the coalition in recognition of the fact that partnership infrastructure is not peripheral to project delivery. It is the delivery.

14. Closing Reflection

What this project demonstrated, above all else, is that the infrastructure problem is solvable.

The barriers facing early-stage builders in West Africa are real and material: unreliable connectivity, limited access to foundational technical education, few structured pathways into global ecosystems, and an almost complete absence of early-stage funding mechanisms designed for the continent's specific context. None of these barriers is insurmountable. But they require interventions that are designed for them not adapted to them after the fact.

The NextGen Developers Hackathon was designed for them. The result, across 16 territories and a six-month cycle, was a cohort of 200-300 individuals who are no longer at the periphery of the Cardano ecosystem. They are inside it: with wallets, with projects, with GitHub repositories, with evaluation experience, and in many cases, with a clear line of sight to future participation in Catalyst funding rounds and ecosystem governance.

The three winning teams are building. The student clubs are active. The model is documented. The lessons are institutionalized.

Africa's technological future will not be built through isolated interventions. It will be built through infrastructure, the kind that compounds: each cohort producing builders who mentor the next; each funded team demonstrating what is possible; each student club generating the candidate pool from which future project participants, future proposers, and future ecosystem contributors will be drawn.

That is what was built here. The work continues.

Beyond The Hackathon

The original Project Catalyst deliverables required the design and execution of a hackathon event which included participant recruitment, event delivery, judging, and grant disbursement. All of those commitments were met and have been documented here.

What the grant did not require and what was built anyway, was a structured post-event product development pipeline.

Following the event, the Better Africa Foundation administered two additional phases to the project's framework.

The first was a structured support and mentorship phase: open office hours and active working sessions giving teams direct access to technical mentors focused on product roadmaps, technical architecture, and Cardano deployment pathways to enable them improve on their product ideas. Whether they won or not, the goal of this entire project was to create inclusivity and validate ideas, not to isolate winners from losers.

The second was the negotiation and establishment of a formal integration pipeline with Remostart's newly established AI and Blockchain Labs to give both winning teams and eligible competing teams a route into a professional development environment with access to engineering mentorship, investor networks, and early-stage infrastructure that would otherwise be entirely out of reach.

This pipeline was not funded by the grant. It was built thoughtfully through the project's relationships, institutional credibility, and the commitment of its partners. It represents what this operation looks like when it is functioning as intended.

Beyond the hackathon, the outcome of a credible technical institution committing its own resources, facility and network to the builders this project surfaced, is the greatest encouragement that this idea was indeed a seed and also the clearest evidence of project quality available.

Duke Peter

Project Lead, NextGen Developers Hackathon 2025

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